

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

AFTER YOU CLOSE

Owning a first home is like learning how to swim. We would be remiss if we threw you into the pool without your arm floaties and left you there to fend for yourself. Once you sign all those papers, receive the keys to the house, and move in, you should be prepared for a few more things.

YOUR FIRST STEPS AS A HOMEOWNER

Priority number one: *Celebrate!* After all that work, you deserve it. Get some sushi. Pop some champagne. Do whatever it is you like to do when you're feeling fancy. Because you *are* fancy—a fancy homeowner, that is!

At closing, you will receive a copy of all the documents you just signed, and some others will follow in the mail. One thing you might get at closing is a payment coupon for paying your mortgage when it is due. You will also get contact information and most likely a payment coupon for any future HOA dues. Don't lose these. If you do lose them or don't have them, contact your agent or lender and ask them for the appropriate payment information.

Your first mortgage payment is due whether or not the mortgage lender sends you a bill in the mail. The date of your first mortgage payment depends on the day you signed all the papers. Your closing rep should tell you if your first payment is due either on the first day of the month after closing or the first day of the *second* month after closing. Pay attention to this—you don't want to be late on your very first mortgage payment!

Any HOA dues are also payable without a mailed invoice. Your taxes and homeowner's insurance should also be wrapped into your mortgage payment, but make sure this is the case when you sign your documents. Reach out to your lender if you're at all confused about when and how to make this payment.